mining, railway and port complex, or in Canada where it acquired established nickel operations, a picture emerges of conflicting corporate images. There is also a marked dissonance between the corporate images projected by Vale and the realities on the ground throughout Vale's global operations.

From an institutional location as a staff member in the Global Affairs and Workplace Issues Department of United Steelworkers (USW), the major union representing mine workers in Canada, I have had the opportunity to monitor this dissonance between Vale's images and practices at first hand over the past decade. I have done so both in Canada after Vale's purchase of the operations of a major Canadian mining company, Inco, and in Mozambique, where USW has had long-standing connections supporting union training programmes through the Steelworkers Humanity Fund. Over the last decade, USW has organised four worker-to-worker exchanges, taking Canadian and Brazilian Vale employees to Mozambique to be part of the resource team for week-long union training courses for Mozambican Vale workers. These kinds of worker-to-worker exchanges have characterised the international work of the USW for many years (Marshall 2009).

In 2011, USW, with support from the Canadian International Development Agency, CIDA, organised a study visit to Brazil for 14 Mozambicans and four Canadians, to see Vale's operations in the north of Brazil at first hand and learn how unions and communities in Brazil were impacted by the mega-project of iron mines, railway and port operation in Para and Maranhão states and what their strategies of resistance were. The participants included Vale employees, community leaders and local and provincial government officials from regions already impacted by Vale projects or to be impacted in future. The USW has also been an active participant in the International Network of People Affected by Vale, starting from its initial meeting in 2010. After retiring from USW in 2012, I carried out a small survey, inviting workers in Canada, Brazil and Mozambique to respond to a questionnaire about their experiences of working for Vale. The results of the survey were incorporated into a paper presented at the III International Conference of the Institute of Social and Economic Studies (IESE) in Maputo, Mozambique, in September 2012 (Marshall 2012). This study of Vale in the context of the BRICS is very much shaped by my participant-observer location and the opportunities it has provided to monitor Vale at first hand.

Vale's practices raise questions of whether multinational corporations based in the BRICS actually differ from global mining companies linked to the historical capitalist and imperialist centres. Vale's Department of Communications and Image works hard to project an image of South–South solidarity, with Brazilian mining investments in the Global South touted to bring with them the jobs and